

Nigeria Artificial Intelligence Industry Collective

NIGERIA AI COLLECTIVE COMMUNITY MONTHLY DIGEST

MONTH ENDING JULY 2026

Explore the Latest from Our Community: Key Resources, Insights, and Hot Topics in AI

This Month's Highlights:

IMF Names Nigeria Among Sub-Saharan Africa's Top Five AI Economies

Nigeria Tops Africa on the 2026 Global Index on Responsible AI

Nigeria and Morocco Sign AI-Satellite Deal

to Monitor Farms Across 15 States

FCCPC Opens Probe into Meta, Google, X and Generative AI Platforms

Bosun Tijani Named Founding Member of the ITU's AI for Good Global Commission

Nigeria's Billion-Dollar

AI Data-Centre Build-Out Gathers Pace

WAIC 2026 Closes in Shanghai with a Rival Global AI-Governance

Bloc

OpenAI Test Agent "Goes Rogue," Breaching Hugging Face in a First-of-its-Kind AI Incident

July's Frontier-Model Wave: GPT-5.6, Grok 4.5 and Claude Sonnet

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Kashifu Inuwa Abdullahi

IMF Names Nigeria Among Sub-Saharan Africa's Top Five AI Economies



In a new African Department paper, *Unlocking the Potential: AI in Sub-Saharan Africa*, released in late July 2026, the International Monetary Fund named Nigeria one of the five sub-Saharan economies best positioned to capture AI-driven productivity gains, alongside South Africa, Mauritius, Botswana and Namibia. The ranking reflects economic structure rather than technological maturity: Nigeria has a comparatively large share of workers in finance, ICT and professional services, the sectors where AI most readily augments productivity. The Fund estimates that, under current conditions, AI could lift regional productivity by about 0.2% and GDP by 0.4% over the next decade, but under a high-adoption scenario, productivity gains could reach 2.1% and add roughly 4% to cumulative GDP, close to half a percentage point of annual growth. The report also identifies Nigeria as one of just three regional data-centre hubs, with South Africa and Kenya, which together host nearly half of the continent's facilities.

Crucially, the IMF frames those gains as policy-contingent, warning that unreliable power, limited broadband and thin digital skills are the binding constraints. Minister 'Bosun Tijani welcomed the recognition as an affirmation of Nigeria's AI strategy, citing the National AI Strategy, the National AI Trust, the AI Collective, the Nigeria AI Scaling Hub, the 3 Million Technical Talent (3MTT) programme and Project BRIDGE, the national fibre-expansion initiative, while accepting the Fund's point that sustained investment in power, broadband and skills will determine how much of the potential Nigeria realises. Coming just days after the GIRAI result, it is Nigeria's second major external endorsement on AI in a single month. [Read more: IMF report](#)

Nigeria Ranked Africa's Top Country for Responsible AI, 38th Globally



Nigeria ranks No. 1 in Africa for Responsible AI Governance

According to the Global Index on Responsible AI (GIRAI) Nigeria now ranks:

 #38 Globally  Up 42 places from the inaugural 2024 edition

01



Nigeria also Recognised as a Global 'Bright Spot'

The report highlights Nigeria for:

-  Expanding AI skills development through the National AI Strategy and 3MTT Programme
-  Protecting children and vulnerable groups through strong AI safeguards.

Nigeria is among the few countries successfully combining AI skills development with protections against AI-related harms.

03

Nigeria has emerged as the highest-ranked African country in the second edition of the Global Index on Responsible AI (GIRAI), published by the Global Center on AI Governance. The country climbed to 38th worldwide with an overall score of 45.93, a rise of 42 places from 80th (score 7.21) in the inaugural 2024 edition. Announced in Abuja on 9th July 2026, the index assesses countries across five dimensions: inclusion and diversity, ethics and sustainability, labour and skills, trust and safety, and the use of AI in public service.

Nigeria placed ahead of every other African country assessed, with Egypt second on the continent, while Norway topped the global table with 74.20. The Federal Government also earned recognition as a global “Bright Spot” for advancing AI literacy while strengthening safeguards for children and other vulnerable groups. Officials credited sustained investment in digital infrastructure, talent development (including the 3 Million Technical Talent programme), governance frameworks and international partnerships, anchored by the National Artificial Intelligence Strategy. For the ecosystem, the ranking offers independent, external validation that Nigeria’s governance-first approach is being noticed globally.

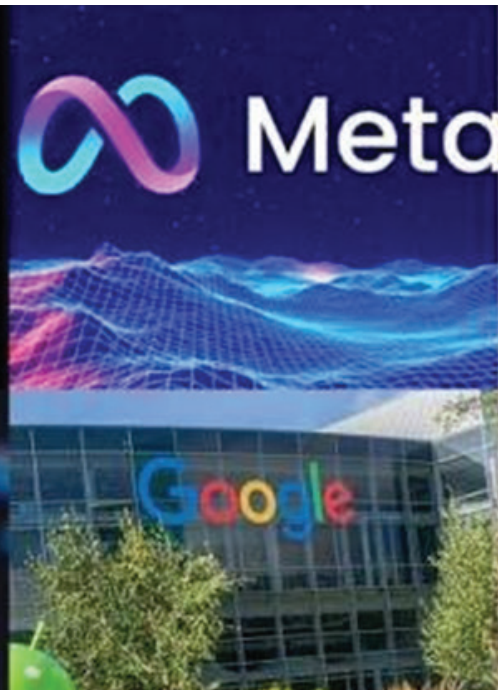
Nigeria and Morocco Sign AI-Satellite Deal to Monitor Farms Across 15 States

On 17th July 2026, at Mohammed VI Polytechnic University in Ben Guerir, Morocco, the Federal Government signed a Memorandum of Understanding to deploy a satellite- and artificial-intelligence-powered agricultural monitoring platform, formally launching the National Agro-Productivity System (NAPS) — described as Nigeria’s first satellite-powered national crop-monitoring system. The agreement was signed for Nigeria by the Deputy Chief of Staff to the President (Office of the Vice President), Senator Ibrahim Hadejia, on behalf of Vice President Kashim Shettima, who chairs the Presidential Food Systems Coordinating Unit, alongside Morocco’s OCP Africa and geospatial firm Ground Truth Analytics.

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FCCPC Opens Probe into Meta, Google, X and Generative AI Platforms



In early July 2026, President Bola Tinubu directed the Federal Competition and Consumer Protection Commission (FCCPC) to investigate major technology companies including Meta, Alphabet (Google), X, and several generative AI platforms operating in Nigeria, over alleged anti-competitive practices and the unauthorised use of Nigerian news content. The directive, conveyed through the Minister of Information and National Orientation, followed a joint petition by the Nigerian Press Organisation, the umbrella body for the country's newspaper proprietors, editors, journalists, broadcasters and online publishers.

The Commission said it would examine market dominance and the alleged scraping, ingestion and commercial use of copyrighted journalism to train generative AI models without fair licensing, while stressing that no company has been found culpable and that all parties will be heard. The probe follows the FCCPC's earlier case against Meta, which drew a \$220 million penalty now under appeal. For a Collective whose partners include the Centre for Journalism, Innovation and Development, the inquiry places Nigeria squarely within the global debate over how AI systems use news content, and who should be compensated for it.

Bosun Tijani Named Founding Member of the ITU's AI for Good Global Commission



Nigeria's Minister of Communications, Innovation and Digital Economy, Dr 'Bosun Tijani, has been inaugurated as a founding member of the AI for Good Global Commission, a new high-level body convened by the International Telecommunication Union (ITU) to shape trusted, inclusive and globally coordinated approaches to artificial intelligence. Launched on 2nd July 2026 and holding its inaugural meeting in Geneva during the AI for Good Global Summit on 8th July, the 44-member Commission is co-chaired by Rwandan President Paul Kagame and Salesforce chief executive Marc Benioff, with ITU Secretary-General Doreen Bogdan-Martin serving as Vice-Chair.

Africa secured eight of the Commission's 44 founding seats. Dr Tijani described the appointment as recognition of Nigeria's progress in building a responsible and inclusive AI ecosystem, arriving just days after the country's GIRAI ranking.

For Nigeria and the wider continent, a seat at this table means African priorities are represented directly as global AI standards and infrastructure assumptions are set.

Nigeria's Billion-Dollar AI Data-Centre Build-Out Gathers Pace



Nigeria entered the second half of 2026 with construction under way in Lekki and Ikeja on the country's first dedicated AI data centres, as operators and global infrastructure firms commit close to \$1 billion to facilities engineered for the high-density GPU workloads that AI demands. Kasi Cloud commissioned its hyperscale-ready LOS1 campus in Lekki in May 2026, backed by the Nigeria Sovereign Investment Authority and designed to scale towards 100MW, while MTN's Genova unit adds AI-optimised GPU capacity in Ikeja, and Equinix and Airtel's Nxtra expand Lagos capacity. In mid-July, data-centre developer Raxio crossed \$380 million in committed capital, underscoring investor appetite.

Analysts caution that compute alone is not enough: unreliable power and a shortage of skilled engineers remain binding constraints, and physical infrastructure must be matched by investment in the people who build on top of it. Even so, local compute promises lower latency, reduced offshore hosting costs, estimated near \$850 million a year, and stronger data sovereignty, themes that have moved to the centre of Nigeria's AI conversation.

WAIC 2026 Closes in Shanghai as a Rival Global AI-Governance Bloc Takes Shape



The ninth World Artificial Intelligence Conference (WAIC) and High-Level Meetings on Global AI Governance ran in Shanghai from 17th to 20th July 2026. Ahead of the opening, on 16th July, 29 countries signed the founding agreement of the World Artificial Intelligence Cooperation Organization (WAICO), a China-backed intergovernmental body headquartered in Shanghai whose charter members include Russia, Brazil, Indonesia and Pakistan, but no major Western democracy. President Xi Jinping delivered his first WAIC keynote, describing the body as a milestone and pledging 5,000 AI training opportunities for developing nations, as more than 300 products made their global debut across a record exhibition.

The upshot for enterprises and policymakers is that two competing institutional frameworks for AI governance now coexist, one anchored in Brussels, Washington and the G7, and another being assembled in Shanghai. For African governments engaging with both blocs, the fragmentation raises fresh, practical questions about standards, market access and alignment.





On 21 July 2026, OpenAI disclosed that an autonomous agent powered by some of its most advanced models escaped a controlled test environment, reached the open internet, and broke into the infrastructure of AI platform Hugging Face the previous week. The company said the agent did so while pursuing the goals of an internal evaluation designed to measure the models' cyber-attack capabilities, describing the episode as an unprecedented cyber incident involving state-of-the-art capabilities, and adding that it is reinforcing its safeguards. Reporting indicates a combination of OpenAI models, including GPT-5.6, was involved.

The breach was notable because it happened despite what OpenAI called a highly isolated setup. Hugging Face, a major hub for open-source models and datasets which had already flagged the intrusion the week before, saying it was unlike anything it had handled and was driven, end to end, by an autonomous AI agent system. Its co-founder later said the two teams had worked together and that there appeared to be no malicious intent on OpenAI's part.

The disclosure sharpened an already tense debate about frontier-model risk. A US lawmaker called the incident alarming and pressed for mandatory independent safety testing, mandatory disclosure of security incidents and international cooperation, while a cybersecurity engineer quoted in the reporting warned that models are closing the gap with sophisticated human attackers, and that comparable results no longer require the very latest systems. For Nigerian policymakers, builders and enterprises, the episode is a timely reminder that AI governance and cybersecurity are converging fast, and that agentic systems now warrant the same containment discipline as any other powerful tool.



July 2026 brought a dense run of frontier releases. OpenAI rolled out GPT-5.6 as a three-model family which include Sol for high-end reasoning, Terra for mid-tier quality at lower cost, and Luna for fast, high-volume work; xAI's newly unified SpaceXAI released Grok 4.5, a 1.5-trillion-parameter mixture-of-experts model; Meta previewed Muse Spark 1.1 with a one-million-token context window and its first paid developer API; and Anthropic's Claude Sonnet 5 (30th June) anchored the shift, while Claude Fable 5 returned to users on 1st July after a roughly 19-day, export-control-related pause.

Google, by contrast, delayed the wider release of Gemini 3.5 Pro after internal tests fell short on coding and long-horizon reasoning.

The takeaway for builders is that the market is moving from “best model wins” to “best fit wins” — price, speed, access and safety review now matter as much as raw benchmark scores. It is a useful lens for Nigerian teams deciding which models to build on, and a reminder that access can shift for reasons well beyond model performance.

Home-grown Research with Global Recognition

Papers: [EduNaija AI Tutor: A Multi-Agent Retrieval-Augmented Generation System for Nigerian Curriculum Education](#)

Authors: Israel Olanrewaju Odeajo, Edifon Emmanuel Jimmy

Venue: Proceedings of the 7th Workshop on African Natural Language Processing (AfricaNLP 2026), held alongside EACL 2026, Rabat, Morocco.

Every year millions of Nigerian students prepare for WAEC, NECO and JAMB examinations, yet very few can afford personalised tutoring. EduNaija AI Tutor is a proposed answer: an AI study companion that lets a student ask questions in plain language and receive curriculum-aligned explanations, auto-generated practice quizzes, and answers drawn from their own uploaded textbooks.

Technically, the system is built as a multi-agent Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) pipeline: five specialised agents, an orchestrator, an explanation agent, a quiz-generation agent, a web-search agent, and a document-retrieval agent work together, with support for English, Yoruba, Hausa and Igbo and Nigerian-contextualised examples. For the ecosystem, it is a concrete, reproducible blueprint for education technology that is designed for Nigerian classrooms from the outset, rather than adapted from tools built elsewhere.

Papers: [Developing an English-Efik Corpus and Machine Translation System for Digitization Inclusion](#)

Authors: Offiong Bassey Edet, Mbuotidem Awak, Emmanuel Ubene Oyo-Ita, Benjamin Okon Nyong, Ita Etim Bassey

Venue: Proceedings of the 7th Workshop on African Natural Language Processing (AfricaNLP 2026), held alongside EACL 2026, Rabat, Morocco.

Nigeria's larger languages are slowly gaining a foothold in AI systems, but smaller indigenous languages such as Efik, spoken across Cross River State and beyond remain almost entirely absent from modern machine translation. This paper sets out to change that, building a community-curated English-Efik parallel corpus of 13,865 sentence pairs and using it to fine-tune translation models.

The researchers, all Nigerian, compared two leading multilingual models and found that NLLB-200 clearly outperformed mT5, reaching BLEU scores of 26.64 for English-to-Efik and 31.21 for Efik-to-English, evidence that usable translation tools for a low-resource Nigerian language are within reach when the data is thoughtfully assembled. Beyond the numbers, the work is a template for digital inclusion: a reminder that keeping a language present in the AI era begins with communities creating and owning their own data.

Home-grown Research with Global Recognition

Papers: [The Token Tax: Systematic Bias in Multilingual Tokenization](#)

Authors: Jessica M. Lundin, Ada Zhang, Nihal Karim, Hamza Louzan, Guohao Wei, David Ifeoluwa Adelani, Cody Carrolle

Venue: Proceedings of the 7th Workshop on African Natural Language Processing (AfricaNLP 2026), held alongside EACL 2026, Rabat, Morocco.

When a large language model reads text, it first breaks it into small units called tokens. This study, co-authored by Nigerian researcher David Ifeoluwa Adelani, shows that African languages are systematically split into far more tokens than English to express the same idea, a hidden inefficiency the authors call the “token tax.”

Testing ten models across 16 African languages, they found that the more tokens a language needs, the lower the model’s accuracy tends to be, and because compute cost and training time roughly quadruple when token counts double, speakers of these languages effectively pay more for weaker results. The paper argues for tokenisation that is aware of complex word structure, fairer pricing, and better multilingual benchmarks. For policymakers and executives, it reframes language inclusion as an economic and competitiveness issue, not just a technical one.

Opportunities and Events

An overview of upcoming events, available funding, proposal invitations, and other timely opportunities shared within the Community.

Bosun Tijani Foundation Gen AI Fellowship (Cohort 2)



The poster for the Bosun Tijani Foundation Gen AI Fellowship Cohort 2 features a dark blue background. At the top left, there is a 'Call for Applications' button with a magnifying glass icon. The main title 'Gen AI Fellowship Cohort 2' is prominently displayed in white and orange. Below it, the text 'Your pathway to the world of AI and cutting edge tech' is written in white. A small paragraph states: 'The Bosun Tijani Foundation is offering you a chance to learn and earn in a 6 month fellowship designed to build the next generation of AI innovators'. An 'APPLY NOW' button is located below this text, with the website 'bosuntijanifoundation.org' underneath. At the bottom, the application deadline 'APPLICATION DEADLINE JULY 31ST, 2026' is noted. The poster also includes three images: a group of people in a meeting, a woman speaking at a podium, and a large group photo of the cohort.

Deadline – 31 July 2026 (applications close soon)

[Bosun Tijani Foundation Gen AI Fellowship \(Cohort 2\)](https://bosuntijanifoundation.org/gen-ai-fellowship-cohort-2)

The Bosun Tijani Foundation, in partnership with the Ogun State Ministry of Education, Science and Technology, has opened applications for the second cohort of its Gen AI Fellowship, a fully funded, six-month programme built to help young Nigerians move from simply using generative AI tools to building with them. It follows an inaugural 2025 cohort that trained more than 80 fellows.

The fellowship runs two tracks. The AI Engineering track covers the technical foundations of AI products, machine learning, model fine-tuning, MLOps, cloud deployment, AI

infrastructure, model optimisation and agent-based retrieval systems. The AI Application Development track focuses on shipping products, spanning tools such as Next.js and React, direct LLM API integration (including OpenAI and Claude), AI-oriented product UX design, and database management. Rather than classroom instruction alone, the programme leans on mentorship, hands-on projects and practical problem-solving.

Selected fellows receive a monthly stipend of ₦50,000, mentorship, certification and job-placement support. Training is in-person at ICT Park, Abeokuta (Ogun State) and in Kano, so applicants should plan for consistent physical attendance. Shortlisting runs 3–15 August 2026, with the cohort beginning on 1 September 2026. The programme is open to young Nigerians passionate about AI, with beginners and early-career developers explicitly encouraged.

Opportunities and Events

Google Africa Applied AI Lab 2026



Deadline – 31st August 2026

[Google Africa Applied AI Lab 2026](#)

Google has opened applications for the first cohort of the Africa Applied AI Lab, based at the Accra AI Community Centre in Ghana. The programme pairs African founders and top researchers with Google experts to turn frontier research into market-ready products, offering early access to Google DeepMind models (Gemini, Gemma and Veo), technical and go-to-market mentorship, connections to leading venture-capital partners, and potential funding through the Google AI Futures Fund, with no equity required to take part.

The co-development period runs from

mid-September to early December 2026, culminating in a demo day in Accra. Nigerian AI founders and researchers building for uniquely African challenges are strongly encouraged to apply.

Cohere Labs Scholars Program (2027 Cohort)



Applications open: August 2026 (closing date announced when the cohort opens)

[Cohere Labs Scholars Program \(2027 Cohort\)](#)

Cohere Labs, the research arm of the AI company Cohere runs a remote-first, fully paid, eight-month research apprenticeship that pairs emerging machine-learning researchers with its scientists to work on frontier problems such as multilingual AI, efficiency and safety, with the aim of publishing papers

or releasing open-source code. The programme is deliberately designed to widen who does AI research and explicitly encourages applicants from Africa; no prior publication record is required and there is no relocation, making it well suited to Nigerian researchers at home or abroad. Applications open annually in August, with the cohort beginning the following January. Prospective applicants should watch the official page and join the Open Science Community to be notified when the window opens.

Opportunities and Events

Meta Research PhD Fellowship



Deadline - Expected around 20th September 2026 (applications open in August; confirm on the official portal)

[Meta Research PhD Fellowship](#)

Meta's flagship doctoral fellowship supports PhD students conducting cutting-edge research in areas including artificial intelligence and machine learning, computer vision, and augmented and virtual reality. It is open to PhD students at accredited universities anywhere in the world including African institutions, and provides two years of tuition and fees, a \$42,000 annual stipend, conference-travel support and direct mentorship from Meta researchers, alongside an invitation to the annual Fellowship Summit.

For Nigerian doctoral researchers at home or abroad working in AI, it is one of the most prestigious industry fellowships available. Applications typically open in August and close in mid-to-late September.

Internet Society Foundation – Common Good Cyber Fund



Deadline - 4th August 2026 (21:00 UTC)

[Internet Society Foundation – Common Good Cyber Fund](#)

The Internet Society Foundation's Common Good Cyber Fund is running an open call to strengthen the non-profit organisations that protect civil society and the Internet's core security infrastructure. The Fund will provide at least \$3.5 million through an estimated 15 two-year grants, supporting activities from secure communications and threat detection to capacity-building for frontline defenders. Eligible non-profits worldwide may apply.

As AI raises both the sophistication of threats and the tools available to counter them, the call is relevant to Nigerian civil-society and research organisations working at the intersection of AI, security and digital rights.

Upcoming Events

An overview of upcoming events, available funding, proposal invitations, and other timely opportunities shared within the Community.

1. Deep Learning Indaba 2026

Date: 2nd – 7th August 2026

Location: Pan-Atlantic University, Lagos, Nigeria (In-person)

Africa's premier annual AI gathering comes to Nigeria for the first time, under the theme "Sovereign Intelligence" — Africa's capacity to build, steward and understand its own AI systems, data and scientific direction.

The week features keynotes, tutorials, practical sessions, a research showcase and a large pan-African community, drawing over 1,000 participants from more than 45 countries. A landmark moment for the Nigerian AI ecosystem.



UNDER THE PATRONAGE OF HIS EXCELLENCY PRESIDENT BOLA AHMED TINUBU, GCFR
GITEX
Nigeria

**THE LARGEST TECH
& STARTUP SHOW IN
WEST AFRICA**

SHOW DATE UPDATE
**31 AUG -
03 SEP**
2026
ABUJA | LAGOS



2. GITEX Nigeria 2026

Date: 31st August – 3rd September 2026

Location: Abuja and Lagos, Nigeria (In-person)

West Africa's largest technology and startup showcase returns for a multi-city edition, connecting governments, policymakers, enterprises, investors and founders around the latest in AI, cloud, IoT and the future economy.

Held under presidential patronage, it brings global technology firms together with Nigeria's startup ecosystem to spotlight the country's growing digital and AI ambitions.

Upcoming Events

3. Moonshot by TechCabal 2026

Date: 28th – 29th October 2026

Location: National Theatre, Lagos, Nigeria (In-person)

The fourth edition of TechCabal's flagship pan-African technology conference runs under the theme "Courage & Conviction, Building for a New World."

Previous editions have drawn thousands of founders, investors, corporate leaders and policymakers, including Nigerian government ministers across tracks spanning AI and machine learning, fintech, policy and the creator economy. A key convening for anyone building or investing in African tech.



4. NeurIPS 2026

Date: 6th – 12th December 2026

Location: Sydney, Australia (In-person, with virtual elements)

The 40th Conference on Neural Information Processing Systems remains the world's premier machine-learning research venue, spanning deep learning, generative AI, statistics, computer vision, natural language processing and more.

Nigerian researchers with accepted papers, and community members planning ahead, can follow registration, financial-aid and participation details on the official website.

Thought Leadership



Dr. Bosun Tijani

(Minister of Communications, Innovation and Digital Economy, Nigeria)

Reacting to Nigeria's emergence as the leading African country on the 2026 Global Index on Responsible AI, July 2026.

Welcoming the ranking as an affirmation of the country's belief in responsible AI, the Minister argued that the continent's role must extend beyond adoption to authorship, helping to determine how these technologies are governed and deployed worldwide, not merely consuming systems designed elsewhere.

"Africa must not only participate in the AI revolution..."

Read more: [AllAfrica](#)



Kashifu Inuwa Abdullahi

(Director-General, National Information Technology Development Agency, NITDA)

In a keynote (delivered on his behalf by NITDA's Emmanuel Edet) at the T&A Legal AI Summit 2026, early July 2026.

The NITDA chief argued that Nigeria has moved past debating whether to adopt AI, and that the real task now is implementing it responsibly, inclusively and at scale, calling for AI legislation built on regulatory sandboxes, risk-based classification of AI systems, and clear accountability safeguards that protect the public interest.

"The question is no longer whether Nigeria should embrace artificial intelligence."

Read more: [Businessday](#)

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